

ENGLISH FLOW PODCAST

Premium Episode Transcript & Guide

MICHAEL

Hello, everyone. Welcome back to English Flow Podcast. I'm Michael, and today I'm here with Emily.

EMILY

Hi, everyone. I'm Emily. I'm so happy you're here. If you are learning English and your morning usually starts with phone scrolling, this episode is for you.

MICHAEL

That's right, Emily. Today we'll talk about a simple morning English routine that can help learners improve without stress.

EMILY

Stay with us until the end because we'll give you a five-minute morning routine and a comment challenge you can try tomorrow.

MICHAEL

And, uh, before we jump in, make sure to visit our website. You can get a free PDF of today's podcast there. Really helps you follow along.

EMILY

Yes, definitely get the PDF. Also, please like this video, subscribe to the English Flow Podcast, and share it with a friend who is learning English.

MICHAEL

Oh, and don't forget the comments.

EMILY

Right. We want you to comment down below, type the words, "***No drama, just direction,***" and then tell us one morning English habit you want to start. So ***no drama, just direction.***

MICHAEL

Awesome. So Emily, let's talk about mornings. Why do we, uh, why do we always reach for our phones right when we wake up?

EMILY

Well, it's because of how our brains work. We have these big, beautiful dreams, right? Like learning to speak English fluently.

MICHAEL

Oh, yeah. That's a huge dream for so many of our listeners.

EMILY

But a dream is just the final stop. It's the magic. Think of your dream like a beautiful garden on the roof of a very, very tall building.

MICHAEL

A rooftop garden. Okay, I like that picture.

EMILY

You wanna be up there. You wanna feel the wind, look at the city, speak English perfectly, but, uh, you can't just fly up there. Gravity exists.

MICHAEL

Right. You need a way to get up.

EMILY

Exactly. You need stairs, and those stairs, the steps you actually put your feet on, those are your goals. A goal is the math. It's the map.

MICHAEL

So the dream is the roof, but the goals are the stairs.

EMILY

Yes, but here's the problem. We spend all our time staring up at the roof. We think, "Wow, learning English is gonna take thousands of hours."

MICHAEL

And that feels really scary.

EMILY

It is scary. Your brain looks at that h- huge building and says, "No way. That takes too much energy."

MICHAEL

Wait, really? Our brains think learning English is dangerous?

EMILY

Basically, yes. Your brain wants to save energy. When a task is too big, your brain gets stressed. It says, "Let's just do something easy and safe instead."

MICHAEL

Ah. And that is why I stay in bed-

EMILY

Mm-hmm

MICHAEL

... and look at funny cat videos on my phone.

EMILY

We all do it.

MICHAEL

[laughs]

EMILY

That brings us to a very important word for today, **distracted**.

MICHAEL

Distracted. That's a great B1 word.

EMILY

Distracted means losing your focus because of something else. For example, I tried to read my English book, but I got **distracted** by a funny video on my phone.

MICHAEL

That happens to me every morning. I'm very **distracted**.

EMILY

So how do we fix this?

MICHAEL

Yeah.

EMILY

Our friends Maya and Leo, who inspired a lot of our thinking today, they talk about something amazing. It's called a **daily anchor**.

MICHAEL

A **daily anchor**, like on a boat.

EMILY

Exactly, like on a boat. A heavy metal anchor goes into the water to stop the ship from floating away.

MICHAEL

How tiny? Give me an example.

EMILY

Well, Maya wants to write a children's book. That's a huge dream, but her **daily anchor** is not writing a whole chapter. Her anchor is just writing exactly 200 words

MICHAEL

200 words? That's not very much.

EMILY

No. It only takes her maybe 10 minutes, and even if the words are bad, she just hits 200 and stops. That is her anchor.

MICHAEL

Wow. And Leo, what's his anchor?

EMILY

Leo wants to run a really long race, a half marathon, but his anchor is just putting his running shoes on every Monday, Wednesday, and Friday.

MICHAEL

Wait, just putting his shoes on? That's it?

EMILY

[laughs] That's it.

MICHAEL

But Emily, putting on shoes doesn't make you a runner. You have to actually run outside, right? Isn't that too easy?

EMILY

I thought the same thing, but it works because of how we start things. It is very hard to start a big task. If Leo says,

MICHAEL

Right. The brain says, "Too much energy. Stay on the sofa."

EMILY

Yes. But if the goal is just put on shoes, the brain says, "Oh, that's easy. That takes no energy," so he puts the shoes on.

MICHAEL

And then what happens?

EMILY

Well, once his shoes are on, he's already dressed for a run. It's actually harder to take the shoes off and sit back down, so he usually just goes outside.

MICHAEL

Oh, I see. He tricks his brain.

EMILY

He does, and this connects to another great word we need to learn today, **realistic**.

MICHAEL

Realistic. Okay, how do we explain that?

EMILY

Realistic means something that is possible and sensible for you to do. For example, learning 10 new English words a day is a **realistic** goal.

MICHAEL

Right, but trying to learn 1,000 words a day is not **realistic**.

EMILY

Exactly. A **daily anchor** must be **realistic**. So let's think about our morning English routine. What is a **realistic daily anchor** for our listeners?

MICHAEL

Instead of scrolling on the phone, maybe the anchor is just opening an English podcast, just pressing play.

EMILY

I love that. The anchor is not study for an hour. The anchor is just listen to one English song or write one sentence in a notebook.

MICHAEL

That feels very safe. It lowers the stress.

EMILY

But, and there's a big but here, even if you have an anchor, your phone is gonna fight you.

MICHAEL

Oh, yeah. The phone always fights back.

EMILY

Maya and Leo call these distractions **dream eaters**, things that eat your dreams.

MICHAEL

Wow.

EMILY

Phones, the TV, a comfortable bed.

MICHAEL

They are very hungry **dream eaters**.

EMILY

They really are. Have you ever told yourself, "I will just check social media for two minutes"?

MICHAEL

Uh, yes.

EMILY

Yeah.

MICHAEL

Every day, and then two hours pass, and I have no idea what happened.

EMILY

Right. The **dream eaters** win because they are so easy to start. You don't need any energy to scroll on a phone.

MICHAEL

So how do we fight the **dream eaters**?

EMILY

Yeah.

MICHAEL

How do we build this morning routine if our phones are so addictive?

EMILY

We have to be **intentional**. That's another vocabulary word for us, **intentional**.

MICHAEL

Intentional. I like that word.

EMILY

Intentional means doing something on purpose with focus. For example-I am **intentional** about my mornings, so I don't look at my phone right away.

MICHAEL

Okay, so how do we get **intentional** against the **dream eaters**?

EMILY

Two ways. First, manage your space. If you want to study English in the morning, do not keep your phone next to your bed. Put it in another room.

MICHAEL

Oh, that's hard. People love sleeping next to their phones.

EMILY

I know, but you have to protect your focus. If you wanna eat healthy-

MICHAEL

Yeah

EMILY

... you don't keep chocolate on your desk, right?

MICHAEL

True. If the chocolate is there, I will eat it.

EMILY

Exactly.

MICHAEL

Yeah.

EMILY

Make the bad habit harder to do. Put the phone away. Put the English book right next to your coffee cup.

MICHAEL

Okay, I like that. Make the good habit easy; make the bad habit hard. What is the second way?

EMILY

The second way is magic. It's called the **10-minute deal**.

MICHAEL

The **10-minute deal**? Tell me about that.

EMILY

When you wake up and your brain feels lazy and you really do not wanna practice English, you make a deal with yourself.

MICHAEL

You talk to yourself?

EMILY

Yes. You say, "Okay, brain, I will only practice English for 10 minutes. I will set a timer. If I still feel terrible after 10 minutes, I'm allowed to stop."

MICHAEL

Wait, you just give yourself permission to quit?

EMILY

Yes, completely free of guilt, but here's the secret: you almost never quit.

MICHAEL

Really? Why not?

EMILY

Because of **momentum**. Here is our next vocabulary word, **momentum**.

MICHAEL

Momentum, that's a fun word to say. Momentum.

EMILY

Momentum is when you start moving and it gets easier to keep moving. For example, I didn't wanna study, but after five minutes I had **momentum** and finished the whole chapter.

MICHAEL

Oh, I see. Getting started is the hardest part.

EMILY

Yes. The **10-minute deal** tricks your brain to just start. Once you start reading or listening to English, your brain wakes up. You feel good. By the time 10 minutes is over, it

MICHAEL

That makes so much sense.

EMILY

Yeah.

MICHAEL

So a good morning routine could be wake up, leave the phone in the other room, sit down with coffee, and make a **10-minute deal** to just do a little bit of English.

EMILY

Listen, speak, write, or review just for 10 minutes.

MICHAEL

I love that. Listen to a podcast, speak a few sentences out loud, write one thing down, or just review yesterday's words.

EMILY

Exactly. But Michael, we have to talk about the hardest part of learning English.

MICHAEL

What is the hardest part?

EMILY

What happens when you do your morning routine for a month and you still feel like you can't speak English well?

MICHAEL

Oh man, that is the worst feeling.

EMILY

[laughs]

MICHAEL

You put in the work, but you see zero results.

EMILY

Yes. A lot of people quit right there. But Maya and Leo share a beautiful story to help us understand this.

MICHAEL

A tree? Okay, how does a tree help us learn English?

EMILY

It's a special kind of tree. When you plant a Chinese bamboo seed, you have to water the soil every single day.

MICHAEL

Okay, water it every day.

EMILY

Yes, but for the whole first year, you see nothing, just flat dirt.

MICHAEL

No little green leaves?

EMILY

Yeah.

MICHAEL

Nothing.

EMILY

Nothing, and year two, still nothing. Year three, you keep watering the flat dirt. Nothing grows.

MICHAEL

I would be so angry. I would think the seed is dead.

EMILY

Everyone would. *[laughs]* Year four, still flat dirt, but then in year five something crazy happens. The tree finally breaks through the dirt and it grows almost 30 meters high in just six weeks.

MICHAEL

30 meters in six weeks? That's impossible.

EMILY

That's what people think. They ask, "Did the tree take six weeks to grow 30 meters, or did it take five years?"

MICHAEL

Oh, wow, it took five years.

EMILY

Exactly, because for those first four years the tree was growing its roots underground.

MICHAEL

Yeah.

EMILY

It was building a massive, strong system under the dirt so it could support a huge tree later.

MICHAEL

If it tried to grow big right away, the wind would just knock it down.

EMILY

Exactly, and this is exactly how the human brain learns a language like English.

MICHAEL

Really? Our brains have roots?

EMILY

Sort of. When you practice your English every morning, you are watering the dirt. You might look in the mirror and think, "I still can't speak well. I see no results."

MICHAEL

Right. It feels like flat dirt.

EMILY

But under the surface inside your head, your brain is building strong roads. It's making new connections. There's a cool science word for this, but we'll just keep it simple.

MICHAEL

It's building the foundation.

EMILY

Yes, and this requires you to be **consistent**. Let's explain the word **consistent**.

MICHAEL

Consistent, this is very important for learning.

EMILY

Consistent means doing something the same way over time. For example, if you study for five minutes every single day, you are **consistent**.

MICHAEL

Even when you feel tired, even when you see no results?

EMILY

Right. You have to trust that the roots are growing. If you are **consistent** with your morning routine, one day the English will just flow out naturally.

MICHAEL

That is a beautiful way to look at it, so don't give up in year three.

EMILY

Please don't give up, but it is very hard, especially because of other people.

MICHAEL

Other people, you mean like friends and family?

EMILY

Yes. We call them the **naysayers**. Naysayers are negative people who criticize your dreams.

MICHAEL

Ah, yeah. I know a few **naysayers**. They're the ones who say, "Why are you studying so early? You're never gonna use English anyway."

EMILY

Exactly. Maya says it feels like someone throws a bucket of cold water on your warm fire.

MICHAEL

That hurts, especially when it's your own family. Why do people do that?

EMILY

Well, it's really interesting. Usually when someone says your goal is impossible, they're actually just talking about their own fears.

MICHAEL

Wait, they are talking about themselves?

EMILY

Yes. If your friend says, "You can't learn English; you are too old," what they really mean is, "I am too scared to try something new, and I don't have the discipline to study."

MICHAEL

Wow, so they wanna pull you down so they don't feel bad about themselves?

EMILY

Exactly. They are projecting, so you don't need to get angry. Just say, "Thank you for your opinion," and go back to watering your bamboo tree.

MICHAEL

That takes a lot of **confidence**, which is another good word for us today, **confidence**.

EMILY

Yes. Confidence means believing in yourself. For example, she spoke English with a lot of **confidence**.

MICHAEL

You have to have **confidence** to ignore the negative people.

EMILY

But Michael, the external negative people aren't the worst ones. The worst naysayer is inside our own head.

MICHAEL

Oh, the internal voice, the one says, "I am so stupid I can't remember these vocabulary words"?

EMILY

Yes. We are so mean to ourselves. If your best friend came to you crying saying, "I'm so stupid I can't learn this language," what would you do?

MICHAEL

I would give them a hug. I would say, "No, you are not stupid. Learning a language is super hard. Look at how much you've already learned. Just keep trying."

EMILY

Right. You would be kind but-But when we make a mistake, we yell at ourselves. We call ourselves names.

MICHAEL

We really do. Why are we like that?

EMILY

We think that being mean to ourselves will make us work harder, but it doesn't. It just makes the brain feel stressed, and then we wanna quit.

MICHAEL

So the advice is to be your own best friend?

EMILY

Yes. Give yourself grace. Progress is messy. Sometimes you take two steps forward and one step backward. That is normal.

MICHAEL

Which brings up a big question. What happens when we mess up? Like, let's say I do my morning routine for a whole week. I don't look at my phone, I practice English,

EMILY

Hmm

MICHAEL

... and Thursday.

EMILY

This happens to everybody. Life gets busy.

MICHAEL

But then I feel so much guilt. I feel like I ruined my perfect streak, and because I feel bad, I just stop studying English for a whole month.

EMILY

Yes. The guilt is the real problem here, not the missed days. There's a story from a listener named Carlos. He did exactly that. He missed three days,

MICHAEL

Poor Carlos. I feel his pain.

EMILY

To help Carlos, Maya, and Leo talk about the **flat tire theory**, this is my favorite part of the whole discussion.

MICHAEL

The **flat tire theory**. Okay, tell me this story.

EMILY

Imagine you are driving your car on a beautiful highway. Everything is going great. Suddenly, you run over a nail, bam, one of your tires goes flat. You pull over to the side of the road.

MICHAEL

Okay. I have one flat tire. That's annoying.

EMILY

What do you do next? Do you get out of the car, look at the one flat tire and say, "Well, I am a terrible driver. My trip is ruined"? And then you take a knife,

MICHAEL

Slash the good tires. No. That is crazy. I would never do that.

EMILY

It is crazy, right? No one would destroy three good tires just because one went flat. You would just fix the flat one and keep driving.

MICHAEL

Exactly. You just put on the spare tire and go.

EMILY

But Michael, this is exactly what we do with our goals.

MICHAEL

Wait. Oh. Oh, wow, I see it now.

EMILY

Carlos had one flat tire. He missed three days of his routine, but instead of just fixing it and starting again on day four, he slashed all his tires.

MICHAEL

That is huge.

EMILY

Uh.

MICHAEL

We get so obsessed with being perfect. If we break our perfect streak, we just destroy everything.

EMILY

*Yes. Guilt is a trick. Your brain uses guilt as an excuse to just quit completely. We need to remember another vocabulary phrase here, "**get back on track.**"*

MICHAEL

Get back on track.

EMILY

It means starting your good habit again after you stop. For example, I missed studying yesterday, but today I will **get back on track.**

MICHAEL

You just fix the tire and keep driving.

EMILY

Exactly. The secret is this: starting again is the superpower.

MICHAEL

I really like that. Starting again is the superpower, not being perfect.

EMILY

Perfect doesn't exist. The most successful English learners are not the ones who study perfectly every single day. They are the ones who fail,

MICHAEL

They fix the tire quickly.

EMILY

Yes.

MICHAEL

Right.

EMILY

Their recovery time is fast.

MICHAEL

Hmm.

EMILY

So let's think about all this for our morning routine. We don't need a huge, scary goal that makes our brain wanna stay in bed.

MICHAEL

Right. No looking at the rooftop. We just need a **daily anchor**.

EMILY

Just one small step on the stairs. Put the phone in the other room to stop the **dream eaters**.

MICHAEL

And use the **10-minute deal**. Just tell yourself, "I'm only gonna listen to English for 10 minutes."

EMILY

Trust the bamboo tree. Even if you don't feel fluent yet, your roots are growing. You are mi-uh, you are building connections in your brain.

MICHAEL

Ignore the **naysayers**.

EMILY

Yeah.

MICHAEL

Be your own best friend.

EMILY

And most importantly, when you have a flat tire-

MICHAEL

Don't slash the other three tires. Just **get back on track** tomorrow

EMILY

Exactly, because **small steps add up**. That is our last vocabulary phrase for today, "**small steps add up**."

MICHAEL

What does that mean exactly?

EMILY

It means tiny actions become a big result over time. For example, five minutes of reading a day doesn't seem like much,

MICHAEL

Five minutes of morning English becomes fluency over time.

EMILY

It really does. You do not need a perfect morning. You just need one tiny 10-minute anchor.

MICHAEL

This has been such a great conversation, Emily. I feel really motivated for tomorrow morning.

EMILY

Me too. And to all our listeners, we have a question for you to think about. Think about an English habit or a goal that you gave up on recently because you missed a few days

MICHAEL

Yeah. What is your own personal flat tire sitting in the driveway right now?

EMILY

And what would it look like to just go out there, fix the tire, forgive yourself, and start driving again tomorrow?

MICHAEL

Just try the five-minute routine. Listen, speak, write, or review. Pick one.

EMILY

And remember our comment challenge. Go down to the comments right now, type, "**No drama, just direction**," and tell us the one morning English habit you are going to try tomorrow.

MICHAEL

We really read every single comment, guys. We love seeing your progress.

EMILY

And don't forget to visit our website to download the free PDF for today's episode.

MICHAEL

Yeah.

EMILY

It has all the vocabulary words we talked about: **consistent, distracted, momentum, intentional, realistic, confidence, get back on track**, and **small steps add up**.

MICHAEL

Such a helpful list. Thank you so much for joining us on the English Flow podcast today.

EMILY

Drop the anchor. Start again tomorrow. We believe in you.

MICHAEL

See you next time, everyone. Keep flowing.

Vocabulary Builder

- **Distracted:** Losing focus because your attention is pulled to something else (e.g., checking a phone instead of reading).
- **Daily Anchor:** A very small, easy-to-start daily habit that keeps you consistently connected to your goal.
- **Realistic:** Something that is sensible and genuinely possible for you to achieve.
- **Dream Eaters:** Addictive distractions (like phones, TV, or comfortable beds) that consume the time meant for your goals.
- **Intentional:** Doing something on purpose, with deliberate focus and planning.
- **10-Minute Deal:** A mental trick where you promise to study for just 10 minutes, giving yourself permission to stop afterward (which you rarely do).
- **Momentum:** The built-up energy you get once you start moving, making it easier to keep going.
- **Consistent:** Doing something the same way regularly over time, even when it feels difficult.
- **Naysayers:** Negative people who criticize or discourage your dreams and goals.
- **Projecting:** When someone pushes their own hidden fears or flaws onto you (e.g., saying "you can't do it" when they mean "I'm too scared to try").
- **Confidence:** Having strong belief and trust in your own abilities.
- **Give yourself grace:** Being kind and forgiving to yourself when you make a mistake or fall behind.
- **Flat Tire Theory:** The idea that if one small thing goes wrong (a missed day), you shouldn't destroy everything else (giving up completely). Fix the tire and move on!
- **Get back on track:** Restarting your good habit after you have temporarily stopped or failed.
- **Small steps add up:** The concept that tiny, daily actions accumulate into massive results over time.

Pro Tips from the Episode

1. **Manage Your Environment:** Keep your phone out of the bedroom. By making the bad habit (scrolling) harder and the good habit (studying) easier, you protect your morning focus.
2. **Use the 10-Minute Deal:** Overcome the dread of studying by committing to just 10 minutes. The hardest part is starting; once you begin, momentum usually carries you through.
3. **Don't Slash Your Tires:** If you miss a day of practice, don't let guilt make you quit entirely. Treat it like a single flat tire—fix it and start driving again tomorrow!
4. **Trust the Bamboo Tree:** Language learning builds invisible "roots" in your brain long before you experience fluency. Stay consistent even when you don't see immediate outward results.

Quick Quiz

1. Why do our brains often avoid big tasks like learning English?

- A) Because the task takes too much energy and the brain wants to stay safe.
- B) Because our brains get bored too easily.
- C) Because we don't naturally like learning languages.

2. What is a "daily anchor" as described by Emily?

- A) A heavy metal object used to exercise.
- B) A very small, realistic habit that grounds your routine.
- C) A 3-hour long study session.

3. What does the "10-minute deal" rely on to help you keep going?

- A) Coffee and energy drinks.
- B) Naysayers motivating you.
- C) Momentum.

4. In the bamboo tree story, what is the tree doing for the first four years?

- A) Growing tall rapidly.
- B) Building strong roots underground.
- C) Waiting for better weather.

5. According to the "flat tire theory," what should you do if you miss a few days of practice?

- A) Quit completely because the streak is ruined.
- B) Feel guilty for a month before trying again.
- C) Just fix the tire and get back on track the next day.

Answer Key: 1: A | 2: B | 3: C | 4: B | 5: C